

Global pandemics

A pandemic occurs when a disease begins to spread over a large region, or even the whole world. Pandemics have devastated populations throughout history. The 1918 Spanish flu, which is thought to have infected a third of the world's population at the time, was the deadliest of the 20th century. More recent pandemics have included the HIV/AIDS pandemic, which began in the 1980s and has killed around 40 million people; the 2009 swine flu pandemic; and COVID-19, which was declared a worldwide pandemic in March 2020.

MAJOR OUTBREAKS

1918–1920

An estimated 500 million people around the world are infected with the Spanish flu, and between 20 and 50 million die from the disease. To stop the spread, social distancing, quarantine, and mask wearing are all put in place, similar to our response to pandemics today.

1957–1968

Asian flu spreads rapidly and creates havoc, but a vaccine is quickly developed to help control the pandemic. It kills more than a million people in two years, before subsiding. In 1968, another similar flu virus appears and kills a million people worldwide.

1976

The first cases of Ebola are recorded in South Sudan and the Democratic Republic of the Congo. Ebola is one of the deadliest diseases in the world and cases are still being identified today. The virus spreads through body fluids, including sweat.

2000s

Major outbreaks in the 21st century so far include Ebola, SARS, Swine flu, MERS, and COVID-19.



COVID-19 VACCINATION

SOLDIERS WITH THE SPANISH FLU ►

The 1918 Spanish flu, one of the deadliest pandemics in history, swept across the world, killing millions. Here, sick soldiers can be seen at a hospital in North America. Unusually, most people who became unwell were young and healthy adults, rather than the elderly who are usually more vulnerable to flu.

